

Resolving an Active Directory Account Lockout

A Help Desk Troubleshooting Walkthrough

Overview

Account lockouts are one of the most common tickets a help desk analyst will encounter. This walkthrough documents a simulated lockout scenario in a lab Active Directory environment, covering how the issue was reproduced, diagnosed, and resolved, and how it would be documented in a professional ticketing system.

Lab Environment

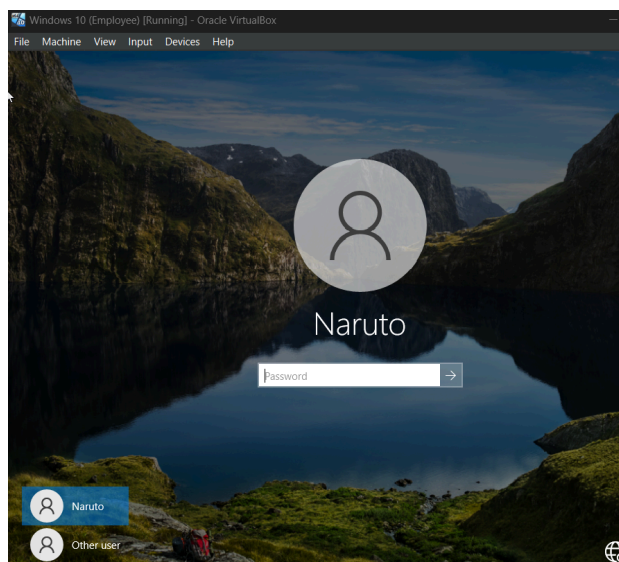
- Domain Controller: Windows Server 2022 (SimoTech.com)
- Client Workstation: Windows 10, domain-joined
- Tools: Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC / dsa.msc)
- Test Account: Naruto, HR organizational unit

Why Lockouts Happen

Windows domains enforce an account lockout policy through Group Policy, typically defined by three settings: the lockout threshold (number of failed attempts allowed), the lockout duration (how long the account stays locked), and the observation window (the time period in which failed attempts are counted). When a user exceeds the threshold, Active Directory locks the account regardless of whether the correct password is eventually entered, until an administrator unlocks it or the duration expires. This is a security control against brute-force password attempts.

Step 1: Reproduce the Issue

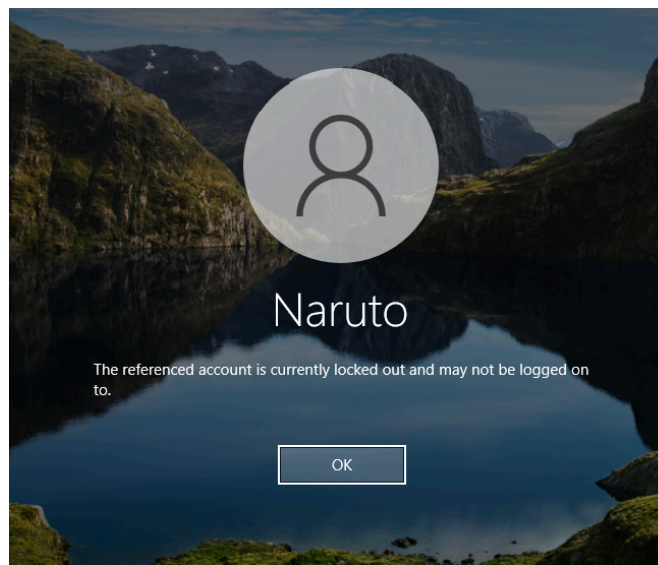
1. On the Windows 10 domain-joined workstation, go to the login screen for the test account.



2. Enter an incorrect password repeatedly (5-10 attempts), exceeding the domain's configured lockout threshold.

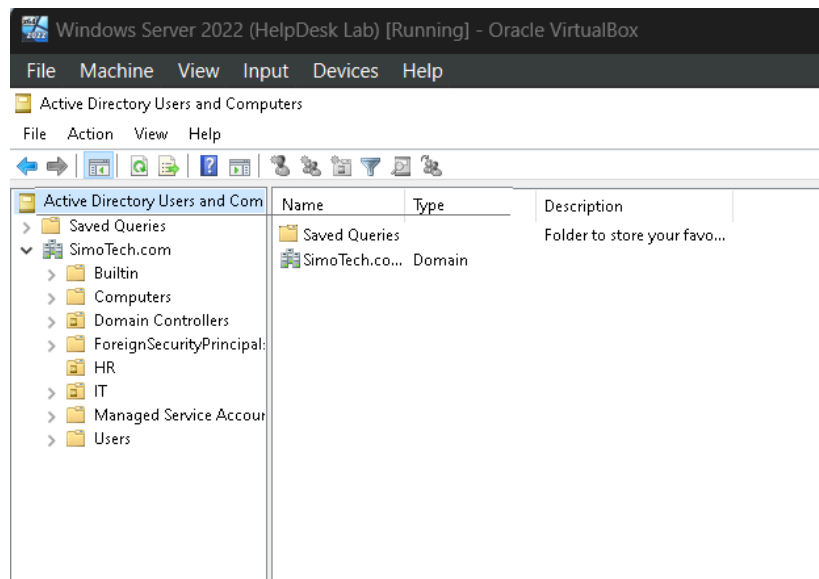


3. Windows returns the error: "The referenced account is currently locked out and may not be logged on to." The account is now locked in Active Directory.

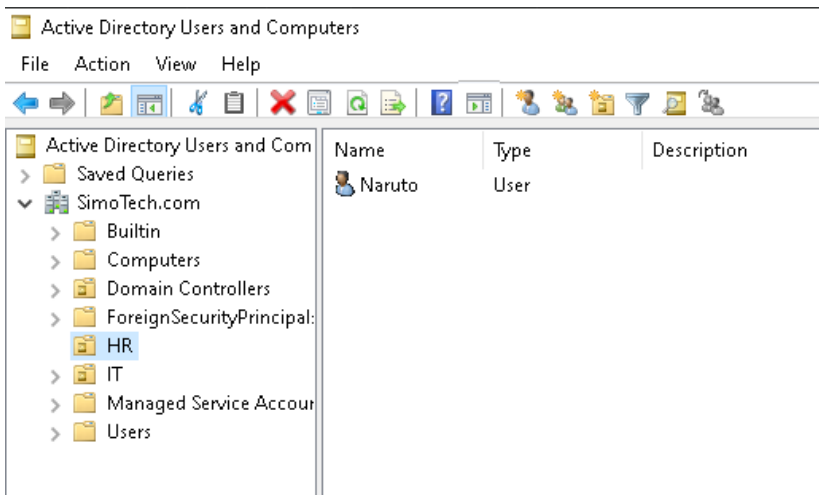


Step 2: Diagnose and Resolve (ADUC)

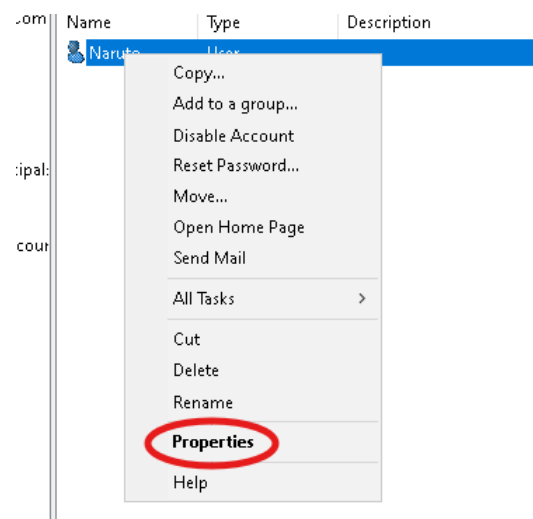
1. On the domain controller, open Active Directory Users and Computers (Windows key + R, then dsa.msc).



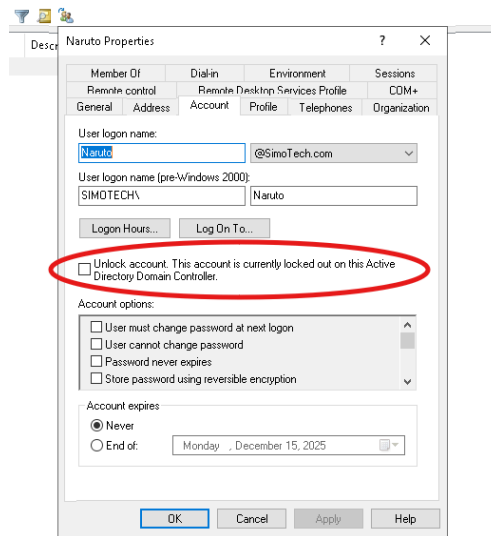
2. Navigate to the organizational unit containing the affected account. In this case, HR.



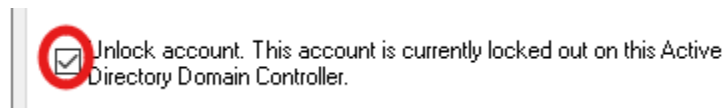
3. Right-click the user account and select Properties.



4. Open the Account tab. The dialog confirms: "This account is currently locked out on this Active Directory Domain Controller."

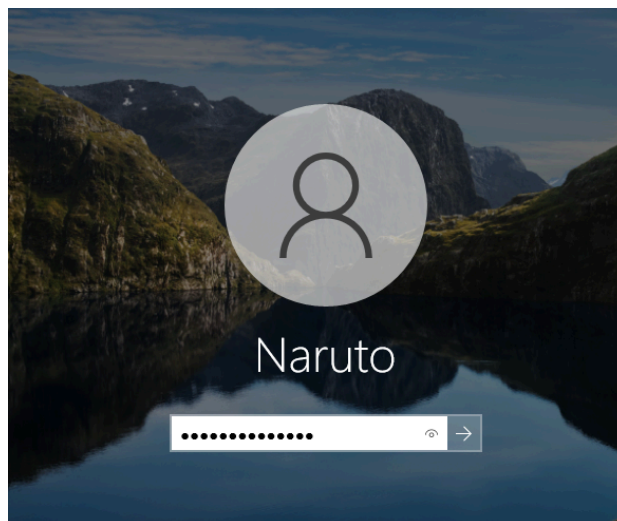


5. Check 'Unlock account', then select 'Apply', then 'OK'.

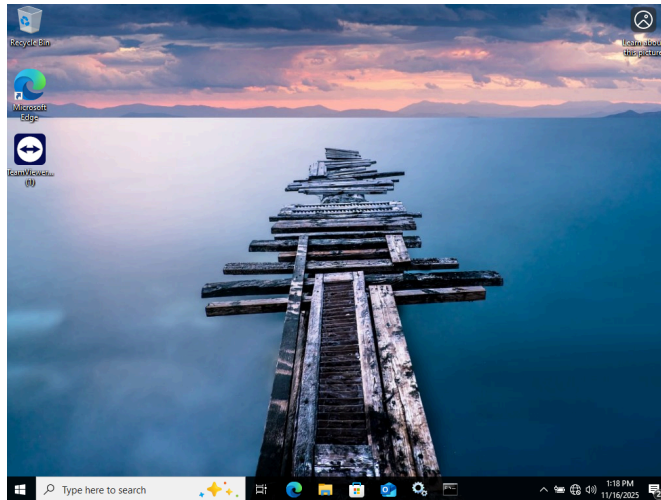


Step 3: Verify the Fix

1. Return to the Windows 10 workstation and log in using the user's correct password.



2. Confirm the desktop loads successfully, verifying the account is fully unlocked and functional.



Ticket Documentation

Below is how this incident would be logged in a ticketing system such as ServiceNow or Zendesk. Compared to a bare activity log, a real ticket captures priority, category, root cause, and resolution time, information that matters for reporting and for identifying repeat issues.

Ticket ID	#2025-1116-001
Priority	P3 - Standard
Category	Active Directory / Account Access
Requestor	Naruto (HR Department)
Issue Summary	User account locked out after multiple failed login attempts; unable to log into workstation.
Steps Taken	1. User reported an account lockout after repeated failed login attempts. 2. Opened ADUC on the domain controller. 3. Located the user account in the HR organizational unit. 4. Opened the account's Properties > Account tab and selected Unlock Account. 5. Confirmed with the user that login was successful using their correct password.
Root Cause	Repeated failed authentication attempts exceeded the domain's account lockout threshold, defined by Group Policy.
Time to Resolution	< 5 minutes
Result	Resolved - user regained access and confirmed successful login.

Preventing Repeat Lockouts

A single lockout is usually just a mistyped password. Recurring lockouts on the same account are worth digging into further, common culprits include:

- A cached or saved password on a phone, tablet, or mapped network drive still using the old credentials after a password change.

- A scheduled task or service running under the user's account with outdated stored credentials.
- An expired password the user hasn't reset yet, still being retried automatically by a device or app.

Checking Event Viewer on the domain controller (Event ID 4740) can help identify which device or source triggered the lockout, rather than assuming it was simply a mistyped password.

What This Demonstrates

This walkthrough reflects core help desk skills: reproducing a reported issue in a controlled environment, using Active Directory Users and Computers to diagnose and resolve an account-level problem, verifying the fix from the end user's perspective, and documenting the incident in a way that would hold up in a real service desk queue. It also shows the habit of looking past the immediate fix to the underlying cause.
